

Disrupting the Architecture of Healing

The development of this brief is largely due to a pre-existing architectural position that has yet to be refined. I consider myself to be a liberal activist and an advocate of decolonising architecture in its various layers.

For this reason, my background and interests from previous projects are especially relevant regarding the theoretical and conceptual approach to this project.

My critical question in general tends to revolve around ways in which designers can break the ideas of binaries, especially regarding the psychological effect of the past and the quiet vs. the fast-paced development of modern civilisation.

It is my intention to apply the practical ideas of phenomenology, feminist theory, and postcolonialism to articulate architectural symbols, styles and language that represent the “subaltern” (Spivak, G.), in order to find the critical “Thirdspace” (Bhabha, H) between the binaries of traditional/modern/eurocentric practice vs. ethnic/feminine/subversive practice.

Deconstruction is the core driver of this interest, as it deals with the philosophical approach towards disrupting binary - which is most suitable for subverting the “norm,” but doing so critically and appropriately.

Following the discussion on Post-structuralism, I took particular interest in the idea of paradox in architecture, and the juxtaposition of signified/signifier in the lexicon of symbolism. What therefore, constitutes an Architecture of Contradiction?

Two of my favourite quotes regarding Art - “Art should comfort the disturbed and disturb the comfortable” (Cesar A. Cruz) as well as “Art is either plagiarism or revolution” (Paul Gauguin). Presuming its symbolic nature, Architecture allows itself to behave as Art or Installation regarding the human experience, one must begin to question exactly what principles are considered tradition, and the epistemological nature of which powers benefit what we know of them.

Studies in Phenomenology will be most crucial the practical approaches to form, space and tactile experience; materiality and tectonics will likely be based off of these precedents.

Kevin Frampton’s critical regionalism is a concept that is well exhibited in the works of Egyptian architect Hasan Fathy, as well as Miriam Kamara, who have both revolutionised use of local materials in practical applications.

Regarding order and spatial programming, the project calls for systematic thinking and an almost empirical assemblage program that allows itself a temporality to expand over time - Dovey articulates the nature of assemblage theory well, and this is seen in practice in Balkrishna Doshi's Aranya housing complex, which consists of an almost organic growth in axis and orientation, but remains ordered without a particular hierarchy.

Ideas regarding circulation and movement between entities are well articulated by the semi-lattice theory in Christopher Alexander's "A City is Not a Tree," and can be seen in transition spaces in Aldo Van Eyck's PREVI de lima compound.

Although these are both related to dwelling, the arrangement of hierarchy is exhibited as one of the most important deliverables, factoring in the power of pattern in the human consciousness.

The ideas of power and signs allude to encouraging/dissuading a certain nature of public behaviour, and it is hence well-known that Architecture encodes a type of cognitive programming in the collective consciousness.

This idea is further explored by Nischolan Pillay, and Yashaen Luckan, who expand on ideas of humanistic urbanism and postcolonial theory in practice: the *genus loci* of a culture is commanded by their built-in cues of meaning regarding built form and space.

For instance, in Asian cultures, some aspects of the wardrobe are kept alongside the main entrance, to accommodate the culture of removing shoes before entering the household. This may suggest a particular sensitivity to floor texture, let alone spatial planning. In Brazilian culture, it is common to shower multiple times a day, and it is custom to invite/be invited to shower in another home before engaging with the family. This may suggest a hyposensitive to water or change in environmental comforts.

Such small intricacies of a culture may be considered uncomfortable to that outside itself - these hold powerful connotations when diverse groups interact in public spaces and where they consider themselves comfortable.

Heidegger articulates the notion of the binary between the city and the village, but this has been criticised and deconstructed even further by Irigaray in "The Forgetting of Air," which elaborates on the feminine nature of fluid motion. Heidegger paints a binary between the heavy slowness and fast-paced electric atmospheres, but completely forgets about the flow between spaces and the implications of literal movement instead of only the built form.

The ideas of the feminine and masculine also begin to speak to what is valued most in the architectural environment.

In the feminist manifesto, "Making Space," some principles are outlined regarding softer and rounder forms, thinking of spaces from the inside out, and prioritising the human scale vs the grandeur of the symbolic form.

This discussion opens itself up to a series of binaries to be considered, but ultimately that which overlaps with itself.

The design methodology I propose would be to examine critical precedents in each binary, while evaluating its practicality in the local context.

There must be some idea of flexibility regarding programme, and threshold space that can be universal. The building design I aim to create therefore must be able to be replicated and adapted to multiple contexts. This is an aim to create a new typology of a mixed-use public-private concoction of ideals that can flourish (or fail) as time evolves. The approach to the built form is never that which should be considered permanent or fixed for eternity.

The first stage of this project will involve a rigorous framework creation that creates a set of design rules and principles for this particular typology.

The accommodation schedule of this program would need to be adaptable as well, but still centred around healing as a whole, regardless of what that may mean over time.

Binaries considered:

Consumerism/Modality

Religious architecture/Architecture of Awe

Minimalism in Commerce

Healing in the City

An interest of late has been the idea of wellness and asylum. Hospitals and medical centres are hardly inspiring for recovering patients. Personal experience can confirm that mental care facilities are less than desired in the urban context. An excellent precedent of a healing rehabilitation centre would be Riverfield Lodge in Johannesburg, South Africa. My time there existed as a bubble removed from civilisation - this is definitely an accelerant to the process, but hardly practical for all individuals in need.

One can question the paradox of needing both the city and the rural - as Heidegger describes the atmosphere of the village that is dense, slow, and sparse, this represents an environment that is not as fast-paced as the harsh and hustling urban city.

[What does it mean to seek asylum?](#)

From what? For who? In the hopes of going where?

Asylum: rehab, refugees, homeless, mentally challenged, neuroatypical.

What does the architecture of healing look like? How can the principles of the natural village be encapsulated within the urban city?

How can time be suspended within this pocket?

Who finds the current system comfortable? How is wellness different for people of colour/the marginalised/subaltern groups?

How can a building be disruptive now but become comfortable in the future?

What is the relationship between ethnic culture and the architecture of healing?

Jumping in and out of civilisation is hardly a sustainable system.

The nature of these questions suggest a type of intervention that expands the ideas of symbols into more than empty signs - an intervention that is unconventionally uncomfortable, meant to represent a place of refuge and comfort.

This building, or form, would have to embody and inspire growth - in and of itself, as well as for its inhabitants.

This suggests a certain type of construction style, and materiality - this may allude to modular assemblage.

The traditional aspects of harmony and healing are associated with places of calm, away from noise, close to nature, and juxtaposed by a type of vastness beyond human scale comprehension. Liminality in practice alludes to the idea of acknowledging beauty while being suspended in the state of two things - a deconstructive thought that proposes that growth is experienced by the end user when they are perplexed, in awe, and given the opportunity to remain in that state of confusion while seeking their own conclusions.

One can typically imagine healing retreats and centres being luxurious escapes into lush natural environments, but what would an oasis look like if it was a vertical pocket in the city?

The ideas of a rehab facilitate a sense of walkability and holistic wellness, as well as perspective due to the sheer scale of nature in the surrounding proximity. Studying ideas of walkability show that this concept is not limited to horizontality. In fact, vertical ascensions of space are more closely associated with spiritual experiences and religious architecture - the traversing of the Eiffel tower steps toward a certain freedom encapsulates this idea.

The principle of a varied, long journey, for different individuals at different starting points, along a vertical axis - this suggests a humanistic stance to the high-rise.

Paolo Soleri seems to touch on ideas of this kind of heterotopia - a seemingly futuristic approach that seems too far-fetched to pursue, but may be the contextually relevant and accessible route to providing calm to the city noise.

This building would have to represent a vertical journey of awareness and perspective, a spatial experience and program accommodating various economies and periods of stay, and inspire continuous meaning on a large and small scale.

The tension of wanting to exist in a system, yet escape that which we have no power in - the awareness that one cannot live in two places at once - is a plague comprising the mental stresses of individuals in our society at large.

This project aspires to soothe the existential longing of being a tree, and being a city at the same time.

THEORY

deconstruction, phenomenology, feminism/queerspace/gender theory, postcolonialism.

QUESTION

how can subaltern/feminine systems of healing be represented in the harsh capitalistic urban context?

ISSUE

rising mental health pandemic of depression, anxiety, suicide ideation, etc.

CONCEPT

mixed use community centre - hotel, mental care/rehabilitation, cross-cultural refugee camp, makerspace and commerce centre.

PRECEDENTS

specifics yet to be selected.

CONTEXT

cities with high crime rates, high suicide rates and influx of refugees, and distinct binaries between socioeconomic classes.

DESIGN METHOD

interrogation and analysis of suitable precedents. Reconfiguration of successful elements to be tested in multiple contexts - project should be adaptable to unique conditions, but have universal formatting for repetition globally.

STRUCTURE:

